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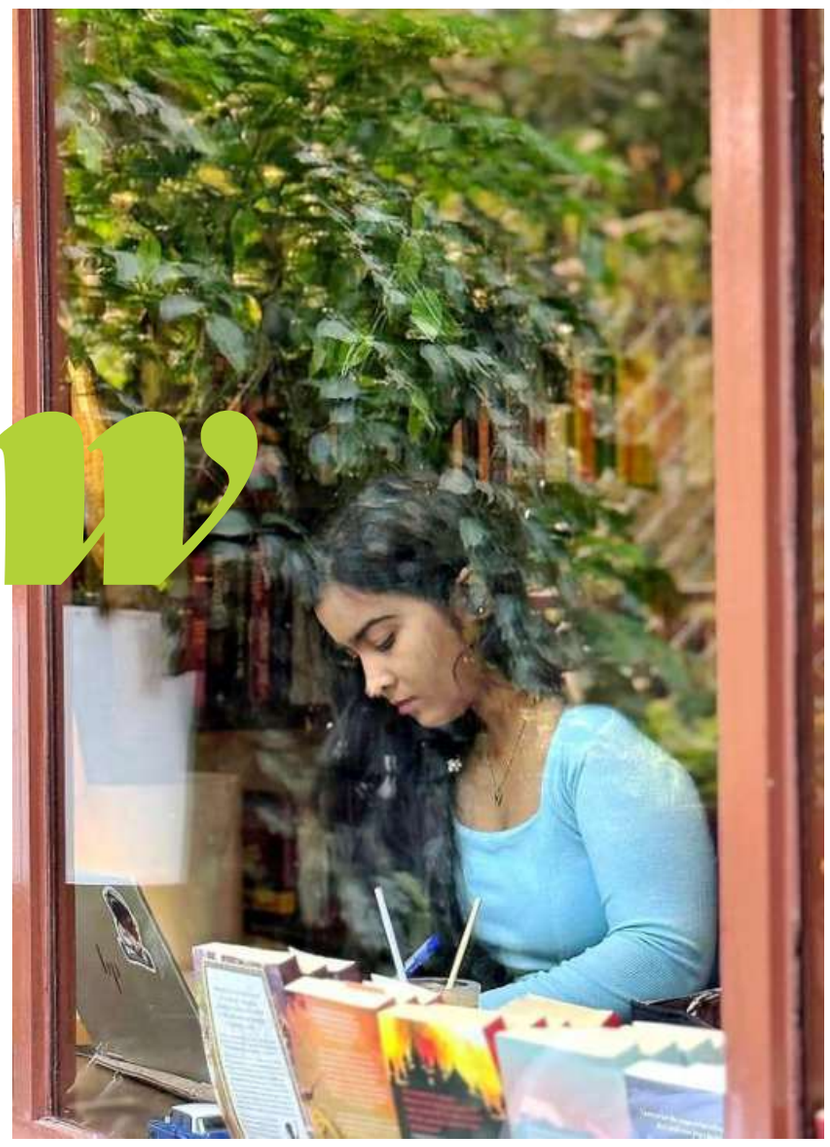
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STAR STRUCK

Jesse Burgess explores the ambition and craft that surrounds chefs chasing a Michelin recognition **P3**

A customer at Bookbar Pune
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Beyond the brew

Good coffee and food may bring customers through the door, but cafés are increasingly relying on run clubs, live gigs, book readings, cultural programming, and viral content to turn visitors into regulars

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When I visited Mokai 2.0, the popular café's expansive new home in Bandra's Pali Hill, a few months after it opened in March 2026, I expected what many viral cafés tend to deliver: impeccable aesthetics, a formidable social media presence and food that merely held its own.

Mokai, which first opened on Chapel Road (also in Bandra) in 2024, had already become a celebrity hangout. Its Instagram account currently has 62,600 followers, while Suraksha, one of its baristas, has emerged as an unlikely social media star.

Mokai's rise says something about what it takes to sell a cup of coffee in 2026. An Instagrammable interior is now merely the entry requirement. In an increasingly crowded café market, social media must generate FOMO (fear of missing out) and keep the café in public conversation after the opening buzz has faded.

That visibility has made the café a sought-after platform for celebrity collaborations, brand launches and film promotions. Director Imtiaz Ali was among its more recent guests for the promotion of his film, *Main Vaapas Aaunga*.

Brands and public figures are not just using the café as an attractive backdrop; they are tapping into its audience, online personality and potential for a viral moment.

Founder Karreena Bulchandani, however, is careful not to mistake visibility for loyalty.

"Social media plays an important role in helping spread the word, but that's where its job ends," she says. "It [social media] may bring people in, but food, drinks and hospitality are what bring them back." For Karreena, a more meaningful measure of success is the regulars who continue to return despite long waiting times.

The new wellness bar extends Mokai's online philosophy into the physical space. Karreena studied skincare and nutrition in Singapore and spent time in Japan learning about matcha before opening the café.

Drawing on the relationship between food, skincare and wellness she encountered across Japan, South Korea and Singapore, she conceived an "inside-out" experience: guests can mill and whisk their own matcha using custom stone mills sourced from Japan, sip collagen matcha and settle in with face or LED masks.

The competition for customers, and their attention, is intensifying. According to Project Café India 2025 by World Coffee Portal, a global research platform, India's branded café market grew 12.7% over the previous year to reach 5,339 outlets.

Café-going is also becoming deeply embedded in urban life. Of the 4,000 consumers surveyed, 24% said they visited a coffee shop every day.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 2









(Clockwise from below) pottery session at LastHouse; a customer wears red light therapy goggles, and the floating matcha bar at Mokai; vinyl corner at Bookbar Pune; Brevé's run club; and game night at LastHouse. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

CONTINUED FROM
» PAGE 1

Beyond the brew

Coffee, however, remains a relatively expensive indulgence rather than an everyday necessity. The average café bill, including food and beverages, stands at ₹660.86 per visit, with espresso-based drinks often costing nearly twice as much as the food they accompany.

For Yash Bhanage, founder and COO of Hunger Inc. Hospitality – the company behind Veronica's, Bombay Sweet Shop, The Bombay Canteen, and Papa's – the conversation begins somewhere less fashionable: consistency. "One of the things that does not get spoken about enough is that true community is built through product consistency," he says.

At Veronica's in Bandra's Ranwar Village, community programming begins with the neighbourhood itself. Guided walks explore the history, homes and smaller details of Ranwar and Pali Village.

Get moving

When Brevé opened in Mumbai in 2020, co-founder Usman Bhadelia, a cyclist and triathlete, imagined a space where athletes, creatives, entrepreneurs and everyday coffee drinkers could cross paths. Soon, weekend cycle rides were ending over breakfast. Some customers who first met at Brevé have since trained for races together, launched businesses and become close friends. "Coffee was the medium through which connections happened," says Usman.

In May, Brevé opened its larger Bandra flagship around 200 metres from the original café. The new outpost is home to Running Late by Brevé, a café-run club. Its WhatsApp community has grown to around 200 members, with between 30 and 40 runners typically joining its Sunday runs after registering through Instagram.

Come one, come all

LastHouse Coffee: By The Lake in Hyderabad just wants its customers to speak to one another.

Architect Naina Polavarapu founded the Jubilee Hills café in 2023. The café has since expanded from 50 seats to around 150-160.

When community manager Katikaneni Amrutha began curating events last year, she hoped to activate The Pantry, the café's retail and community space. "Even though we had large community tables, nobody spoke to each other," she says, adding, "we've always wanted LastHouse to feel social."

The programming reflects interests already taking shape in the city. LastHouse sells vintage cameras and film rolls, connects customers with local film developers and works with one of Hyderabad's few second-generation analogue-camera repair specialists.

Other collaborations include portrait sessions with The Sketching Collective. Programming, however, requires continual reinvention. "We're constantly learning what works," Amrutha says. "A game night might sell out the first time, dip the second and almost disappear by the third.





Then we have to rethink the format."

The team now curates niche tabletop and social-deduction sessions instead of generic game nights. Other formats have proved more durable: weekly workshops with The Pottery Circle routinely sell out, attracting 45-60 participants per session, with multiple sessions often held on Sundays.

Amrutha now works with around 35 community partners from Hyderabad and elsewhere in India.

Music at 11am

At Kat & Kin Coffee Roasters, on South Cross Street in Chennai, co-founder Anek Ahuja is wary of allowing programming to overshadow the cup. "Coffee has always been what we're known for,



and we're never going to negate that experience," he says.

The family-run business began during the COVID-19 lockdown in 2020, when Anek and his wife, roast master Kathryn, went looking for good coffee and decided to roast their own. Funded entirely through their savings, the business grew into a dedicated roastery and, in 2023.

Over time, Anek recognised that good coffee alone would not necessarily bring new customers through the door. Rather than pay influencers to photograph its drinks, Kat & Kin turned to live music.

The café's first gig featured his own band, Blues Conscience, and was free. When the space filled up, he recognised an audience for live music at an unusual hour: 11am on Saturdays.

The morning slot removes some of the friction associated with evening gigs. "There are older people who don't want to go to bars to watch a band. Here, you come for a one-hour gig, the music is good, the environment is good, you have a coffee and something to eat, and then you have the rest of your day," says Anek.

The format has created a daytime platform for Chennai's independent musicians. Tickets cost ₹499, of which ₹400 goes directly to the performing band; the remainder largely covers ticketing-platform commissions and taxes. Kat & Kin's performance calendar is often booked two months in advance.

For a cafe with only 28 seats, the response has been significant. Some gigs have drawn around 45 people.

Open book

Long before "community" became the café industry's favourite buzzword, co-founder Avneesh Gadgil of Bookbar in Pune, was building one around books, poetry and independent cinema in Pune.

Bookbar recently opened a compact café in Bandra, where Avneesh estimates that around 90% of the books have been donated. Bookbar's Pune libraries, too, have grown largely through community donations.

The cafe has also moved from hosting writers to publishing them. Its first book, *Beyond the Drafts*, brings together poetry by writers connected to the café's community. Its cultural programming extends to cinema. Bookbar has hosted the Pune Film Movement, a collaborative filmmaking collective that brings aspiring filmmakers and cinephiles together.

In Mumbai, Yash says, the economics of running a café has become considerably more difficult over the past five years. "In many cases, people are opening cafés or restaurants with rental commitments that are not scalable or sustainable in the long run."

Community, then, cannot be separated from the fundamentals of running a café.

pick of the week



Groove mates

Chennai-based drummer-percussionist duo SNAX, comprising Kanaxx and Sumesh, brings a decade of musical camaraderie to the stage guided by the simple joy of making music together. Catch the duo at an initmate morning concert, *@Kat & Kin Coffee Roasters, Neelankarai on October 3 at 11am. Tickets cost ₹499 and available on bookmyshow.in*



Weekend stage

Akvarious and LATTE present The October Theatre Fest with four plays through the weekend. Saturday brings *Excess Estrogen,* where six women take the stage, followed by *This Time*. Sunday has *Dekh Behen Part 2*, followed by *Love, Bombs and Apples*.

@ Sir Mutha Venkatasubba Rao Concert Hall, Harrington road, on October 3 and 4. Tickets priced at ₹499 onwards and available on bookmyshow.in



Tipsy tussle

Got a hot take? Bring it to The Drunken Discourse, Chennai's tipsy contrarian debate club organised by Popverse Production, where controversial opinions meet a chilled glass. Say something outrageous, defend it or simply sip and watch the chaos unfold. There is much to debate over.

@Rhapsody by Courtyard Mariott, Teynampet on October 3 from 3pm to 7pm. In English and Tamil, for ages 18+. Tickets priced at ₹300 and available on bookmyshow.in



Heart songs

Musicians AKR, Anu Keerthi and Nivasinee will take the stage for a concert organised by Thiruvizha Chennai, to support singer and multi-instrumentalist Jyothi Kalai. The evening will celebrate the spirit of community coming together to encourage and support one another.

@Pagir, Thiruvanmiyur on Octrober 3 at 6pm. Tickets priced at ₹120 and can be booked via @thiruvizhachennai on Instagram.

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Forms of change

In Artiform Mylapore, Material Memoir explores everyday materials as vessels of memory, observation, and storytelling

In Material Memoir, a new show at Artiform, Mylapore, substances like wood, metal, and graphite, move beyond their physical forms to become ways of telling stories. Carved, layered, cut, shaped, each material gradually becomes a part of a narrative.

The exhibition brings together the works of upcoming Chennai-based artists Kannan P, Mani Murugesan, Ramki Ravi, Ramesh N, Surya S and Yogeshwaran V. Some pieces quickly announce the idea of contemplating material memory and the central nature of life through indents, and suspension. There are some others that show you the palpable changes taking place in Nature through nests and webs.

Kannan's practice, for instance, evidently engages with welding, sheet metal, wood, and bronze. One of his pieces titled Metallic Nest: Solitude and Synergy, made entirely with steel, is inspired by the "collective architecture of the wasp's nest," says Kannan. Growing up in Chennai's Ambattur, the presence of a wasp's nest is something that he witnessed often. "A single paper wasp or honeybee cannot build a hive alone, yet together they craft complex structures through collective labour. In my practice and in life, I believe true strength and beauty emerge not from isolated creation, but from shared unity," says Kannan.

"Every time I clean a spider's web in my house, it rebuilds again and again. Watching this cycle sparked a deep personal realisation...For me, this only means that I need to keep moving forward despite every obstacle or setback. That is what I have tried to do in Perseverance," he adds.

Kannan says that the way he has used steel to construct a suspended human takes the form of a spider's home and its infinite web.

"We think of wood, graphite, paper, metal, and all these materials as just something that is used to create an artwork. But when you actually look closely, they are not just materials. That is where the story begins. Each artist has approached the material in a different way, and even though their styles are distinctive, the material they have used carries an evocation," says curator Isaiarasi Annamalai.



Forms of Nature

There are other artists who seem to be gravitating towards hymenoptera, arachnids, and other small creatures. Artist Ramki Ravi transforms paper through cutting, carving, and layering, challenging the material's inherent flatness. Inspired by the forms of Nature, the sculpted pieces draw upon forms such as honeycombs, fingerprints, and patterns of insect movement.

The first work that catches your eye is titled Apian Society, made with paper and gold foil texture paste. The artwork is in all shades of orange and bright yellow; in some ways, it also reminds me of the golden hour





(Clockwise from left) Artworks by Kannan P; Ramki Ravi; Ramesh N; and Yogeshwaran V. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

evenings. The artist says that this artwork explores collective living through a honeycomb structure, highlighting how individual contributions create a harmonious society without rivalry or envy.

Another work that catches my attention is titled Constellation, made with acrylic on canvas; the work resembles a starry night, a rare occurance for city dwelling people. For the artist, it denotes the endless thoughts that inhabit a human mind. "From waking to sleeping, the flow of thoughts appearing and disappearing resembles a starry night sky, expressing the ceaseless flux and energy of countless thoughts," says Ramki.

For artist Ramesh, much of his works draw inspiration from his recent travels to Kochi in Kerala. He uses etching, woodcut, and mixed media to show crabs, boats, and the shore as recurring themes. In one work, dense tree roots envelop the boats, while in another, a school of fish swims alongside them. All these paintings seem to inherently carry forward a philosophy of mushrooming from one's roots.

Internal voice

The exhibition also brings to us many external philosophies. Born in Kalpakkam, Tamil Nadu, artist Surya S was raised in a village environment, which shaped his sensitivity to everyday life. His work General Perspective, made with a mixed media of paper, wood, and steel, resembles a pinball game . But the artist says, "the things we witness, learn, accept, and question gradually shape our sense of identity and belonging. What begins as an external influence eventually becomes an internal voice."

Artist Murugesan's works draw on scientific thought, philosophical enquiry, and close observations of Nature, ideas that are also echoed in their titles, such as Dialectics, Primary Energy, and Inter+Outer+Infinite. In Dialectics, made with graphite on paper, the artwork calls for multiple observations. The work seems to reveal itself differently every time, making it an object of intrigue.

Yogeshwaran, explores human emotion, resilience, strength, and the expressive possibilities of form. He transforms industrial materials like bronze, steel, and iron into forms that appear to float, rotate, or move through space. His sculpture, Midday Night, made with cotton steel, captures a moment of celestial eclipse. "The spiralling, concentric metal bands represent the orbital motion of the cosmos, while the two polished central spheres embody the sun and moon becoming one," he says.

Material Memoir is currently on Artiform, Mylapore till October 31. The sculptures are priced ₹30,000 onwards.



The star *pursuit*

Knife Edge host Jesse Burgess reveals what Michelin stars measure, why chefs chase them, and why Indian food keeps him coming back

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Ever wondered what a Michelin Star actually means, or what earning one of the highest honours of the culinary world tells you about the food on your plate?

For roughly a decade, British food and travel content creator Jesse Burgess has been trying to get closer to the people who know the answer from the other side of the pass. He is the co-founder of TOPJAW, the food platform he runs with filmmaker Will Warr, where he has interviewed chefs, actors, and food obsessives about the restaurants they genuinely love returning to.

TOPJAW has grown into a global food platform with more than a million followers, giving Jesse a career spent moving between the people who make great food and the people who know where to find it. Now, as the host of Apple TV's *Knife Edge: Chasing Michelin Stars*, he is following the most gifted chefs from around the world to find answers to the considerably more nerve-racking question: what does it take for a restaurant to convince Michelin that its cooking belongs among the very best on the planet?

Executive produced by Gordon Ramsay through Studio Ramsay Global, *Knife Edge* follows chefs as they try to earn, retain, or increase their Michelin stars. The first season travelled through restaurants across the United States, Europe, and Mexico. Season two follows 16 restaurants across several countries, including Gareth Ward's Ynyshir in rural Wales and Nathan Davies's Vraic in Guernsey. Jesse and the team also get unprecedented access to Michelin inspectors, whose reports help determine whether a restaurant receives a star while their identities remain hidden from the chefs they are judging.

Michelin myths

The anonymity has been part of the Guide's system since 1933, which has naturally given Michelin inspectors an almost folkloric status in the culinary world. They book restaurants under assumed names, pay their own bills, and can return for another meal when a decision requires more evidence. Michelin says they assess five things: the quality of the ingredients, the execution of the cooking, the chef's personality in the food, consistency across the menu, and consistency between visits, but Jesse has discovered that much of the folklore is considerably more colourful than the actual job.

"There are a lot of myths around Michelin, which have been really fun to kind of debunk or find out the truth," Jesse says. He had heard that a dropped fork could count against a restaurant if somebody did not pick it up quickly enough, while another rumour claimed that an inspector forced to queue for the toilet could lose the restaurant its star. Neither is true. "The inspectors are effectively there just to judge what is on the plate in front of them," he adds.

(Clockwise from left) Jesse Burgess; and stills from from *Knife Edge: Chasing Michelin Stars*. APPLE TV







Apple describes the new season as 16 restaurants at pivotal points in their Michelin journeys. Jesse says the basic selection philosophy has remained much the same.

"I don't think a huge amount has changed in terms of the restaurant selection from season one to two," he says. The casting team, led by Gia Ramsey, was looking for "great stories", which is why the likes of Ynyshir and Vraic stood out.

> ***The Michelin star is a wonderful justification. It is a real accolade, a pat on the back that affirms that you have committed, strived, learned, honed your craft, and now joined this club of other restaurants that are considered some of the best in the world***
>
> **JESSE BURGESS**
> co-founder, TOPJAW

Platter ratings

So what does the Star give them? "The Michelin star is a wonderful justification," Jesse explains. "It is a real accolade, a pat on the back that affirms that you have committed, strived, learned, honed your craft, and now joined this club of other Michelin star restaurants that are considered some of the best in the world."

That idea of justification is important to how Jesse sees Michelin's relevance today. A chef can spend years refining a menu, or training a kitchen and building a restaurant around a particular standard, yet there is no universally recognised point at which someone can say the work has reached a particular level. Michelin provides that marker for restaurants within its territory. Jesse calls it "a wonderful badge of actualisation."

The catch is that Michelin's map remains notoriously incomplete. "Obviously, the Michelin Guide isn't everywhere," Jesse says. "It isn't in India, for example" – the omission is a big one because "some of my favorite meals I've ever had are in India," he explains.

It all ultimately boils down to the food itself, and Indian cuisine seems to keep pulling him back. "I love the sort of curries that you get in the south of India," he says. "The stuff that is very coconut-based is a lot lighter, creamier, and somewhat sweeter at times." He is also fond of Punjabi food and the tandoor. "The flavours just aren't as deep and rich and as smoky" in the versions he had encountered in the West, he says. "I just like that dry spice and those punchy flavours."

His favourite Indian meal came from a place he had never heard of and would probably never have sought out. During his Rickshaw Run across the country with Will Warr, the pair arrived late at a guesthouse in an unspecified dry State. The owner told them there was only one thing available: a paneer curry made by his mother. They were, Jesse remembers, probably the only guests in the hotel. He had already been eating Indian food for weeks, so this was hardly the thrill of a first encounter. "I would like to go back to the State just to have this *one* curry because it blew my mind," he says. "It was the best paneer curry of my life." He also remembers Mumbai fondly; specifically the Butter Chicken Factory, which he admits "is probably really silly to you guys. But it was awesome."

He was in India eight years ago but there is no return date on the calendar yet. "I can't point to a plan as yet. But I will be there before long. I can't let it get to 10 [years]."

Knife Edge: Chasing Michelin Stars Season 2 *is now streaming on Apple TV*



Hard landing

Ritu Arya and Tewfik Jallab on Zara and Vincent's dark worlds and the adrenaline-fuelled *Apollo Has Fallen*

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The globetrotting action series, *Apollo Has Fallen* sees Vincent, a former soldier in the French Army and MI6 agent Zara facing threats that include hijacking, kidnapping, and a bio-weapon. Betrayal and deceit foster a sense of not being able to trust anyone.

In the explosive first episode, Zara, played by British actor Ritu Arya, makes the difficult decision to leave Vincent (Tewfik Jallab) behind. "It's interesting where we find them at the beginning of this season," Ritu says over a video call from Paris.

In *Paris Has Fallen*. Vincent and Zara go through a lot together, Ritu says. "They have learnt to trust, respect and even grow fond of each other. I don't think Zara realises how dependent she is on Vincent until she thinks she might lose him. It is a shock to her how much she's affected by the knowledge, and how vulnerable that makes her," says Ritu, "It was great to play that emotional arc this season alongside the big, action set pieces. She's in fear and doesn't know how to go on without Vincent." Tewfik, also speaking from Paris, laughs, saying, "I was so happy to be separated from Zara. It was chill, there was no pressure."

In reality though, the French actor says, getting serious, "Vincent and Zara have this natural dependence on each other. You realise you care about someone when you think you might lose them. While Vincent knows that he's alive, and there is a possibility that he will survive, somewhere at the back of his mind, he thinks, 'Zara might save me'."

There are further complications in Zara and Vincent's relationship when Vincent falls in love. Tewfik adds, "There is a betrayal in the friendship between Zara and Vincent. When they are separated, Vincent thinks about Zara all the time and when they reunite it is a climactic moment for my character."

Unwilling to talk about the twist that surprised them, because as Ritu points out, that would be a spoiler and Tewfik pitches in with, "She is my boss," the actors speak instead of their most challenging scenes.

For Tewfik, playing a man infected with a deadly virus was difficult. "How do I play that? How do I play a man who would probably die soon, who only has a few hours left? It was probably the most technically difficult thing to play."

Ritu talks about an action sequence in a supermarket, which proved physically demanding. "We're running around Chinatown in London on a Sunday," Ritu says. "So you can imagine the chaos. Then we dash into this Chinese supermarket where there is a chance of mercenaries coming through any of the aisles. Zara is juggling her hyper vigilance whilst protecting a screaming civilian clinging onto her, and we had half a day to shoot it," Ritu says laughing. "So that was quite challenging. But it looks great."

Ritu Arya and Tewfik Jallab in *Apollo Has Fallen*. LIONSGATE PLAY

Apollo Has Fallen *is currently streaming on Lionsgate Play*













(Clockwise from far left) Manta rays; and snapshots of the Four Seasons Resort Maldives at Landaa Giraavaru. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

At Four Seasons Resort Maldives at Landaa Giraavaru, guests get a resort-issued phone that alerts them when researchers spot manta rays. An experience that offers a front-row seat to the marine life of Baa Atoll

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Did you know that the Maldives hosts the world's largest population of reef manta rays, and the third-largest population of oceanic manta rays? To see these magnificent creatures, I head to Landaa Giraavaru, a 44-acre island in the Baa Atoll of the Maldives.

I opt for the resort's Manta on Call service, which provides guests with a resort-issued phone that can ring anytime between 9 am and 6 pm when researchers spot mantas.

One morning, I am walking along the island's tree-lined pathways, and the next minute I am on a speedboat to Hanifaru Bay, a key aggregation site for manta rays. Guided by marine biologists at the Trust, I snorkel into the belly of Hanifaru Bay where I witness these stunning creatures up close.

Plantation to luxury resort

Ali Suaidh recalls visiting Landaa Giraavaru with his grandfather to collect coconuts two decades ago. "The island historically served as a coconut plantation where locals would visit to collect the drupe that they then traded. We were 26 cousins, and our grandfather used to bring us on a boat every Saturday," Ali (fondly called Ayya), the resort's Sales and Public Relations Supervisor, reminisces as he drives me on a buggy across the island that has been home to the Four Seasons Resort Maldives at Landaa Giraavaru since 2006.



Over the next three days, I get to experience the island in all its glory, with the turquoise, cyan and deep blue waters for company. Now a protected island within a UNESCO World Biosphere Reserve, it blends luxury with marine conservation.

Landaa Giraavaru, meaning 'moving sand', is an ode to the region's changing currents and reflects the many changes the island has undergone over the last 20 years. On a quick tour of the property with a bottle of lomi lomi (a soothing blend of ginger juice, lime juice, and honey) in hand, Ayya tells me how the resort will always be a work in progress: regular upkeep of the property, new villas and categories being added, and expanding their marine initiatives.

Swim with the rays

No visit to the island is complete without experiencing Baa Atoll's thriving marine life, and Landaa Giravaaru's Marine Discovery Centre (MDC) ensures I have had my fill.

Led by a team of marine biologists, the on-island research centre is home to a fish lab, Turtle Rehabilitation Centre; a Reefscapers programme helmed by the Madivian marine consultancy specialising in coral reef restoration and marine research; and the Maldives Manta Conservation Programme (MMCP), which turns 20 this year.

Sophie Owsianka, Project Manager, Manta Trust, explains that while the Trust has 30 affiliate projects worldwide, "it all started here, in Landaa". In addition to Manta on Call, they offer manta safaris, private trips, and a range of child-centric experiences. "Every Friday, we host an interactive presentation on manta rays that includes fun quizzes. We also have a comprehensive Trainee Marine Biologist Programme targetted at 13 to 18-year-olds wherein they get to research on everything from corals to dolphins," says Sophie.

Beyond marine conservation, the property's sustainability-focussed vein extends to engineering and property management. On a tour of their backend operations, Adam Moosa, chief engineer, explains that they consume 380 cubic metres of water every day, which includes 1,200 bottles of drinking water for guests.

As we walk past their employee barber shop, gym, and recreational area, Adam talks about the property's focus on alternative power sources. "We have incorporated solar power since 2017, and an ongoing pilot project for floating solar panels is ongoing." Other sustainability initiatives, he says, include recycling 100% of their landscaping waste and composting 30% of food waste.

Umabe, the "legend"

As I pass by off-duty staff relaxing in their lounge or getting a quick workout, the path leads us to Cafe Umabe.

This employee cafe, Adam says, is named after Umabe, a local who was integral to creating the resort. "He educated the team about the island: its vegetation, and how the property should be designed. He welcomed the first guests, and sadly passed away a year after we launched," says Adam.

Ayya refers to Umabe as a "legend". "He understood the island more than anyone. I still remember his muscular build and our interactions when I was a child. I used to visit the island with my cousins and climb palm trees for their fruit. Even if we'd cut one from the hundreds of trees, he would just know. He was silent, observant, and cared deeply for the island," concludes Ayya.

The writer was in the Maldives on invitation from The Four Seasons Resort Maldives at Landaa Giraavaru



(Clockwise from below) The resort's lounge area; snapshots from the safari; and Kings Lodge. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Thrill of the wild









We step into Madhya Pradesh's Bandhavgarh forests to see tigers. We come back with a grand sighting, lessons on ecology and responsible tiger tourism

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Samrat stayed, unmoved. He yawned a bit. His gaze settled somewhere in the middle of our jeep. And then, for a full couple of seconds – which would seem like eternity for all of us seated inside the vehicle – Samrat stared straight.

We froze. Everyone thought that the animal was looking at them.

In that moment when the world seemed to come to a startling halt, someone shouted, "Camera...picture", after which we came to our senses to reach out for the visual instruments to capture the moment.

Slowly, Samrat started to move away. In a few seconds, he would cross the road and disappear into the bushes...but not before turning back to glance at us.

He had seen us. At Bandhavgarh, a board with a tiger near the exit gate reads, 'Don't be disappointed if you do not see me. Because, I have seen you.'

Samrat is one of the 100-plus tigers for whom the muddy lanes of Madhya Pradesh's Bandhavgarh is home. Samrat translates to 'king' in Hindi, and this massive, male Bengal tiger strolls the Tala and Khitauli zones of the park with carefree abandon.

"Samrat was my first sighting here, so he is special," Viswajit Singh Solanki, a tour guide, tells me about this 8-year-old tiger. "He lives on the hills and is quite elusive."

We are driving slowly along the muddy lanes of Bandhavgarh, declared a tiger reserve in 1993 after being a National Park for a few decades. The state – Madhya Pradesh – itself leads India's tiger census, with more than 780 tigers spread across its wildlife reserves.

While Bandhavgarh boasts considerable variety in flora and fauna, including the Indian pitta and crested serpent eagle, the tiger remains the focus. It is home to 164 tigers, according to the last population census, out of which 35 tigers are accessible to tourists in core and buffer zones.

Spread across 1536 square kilometres, the reserve is divided almost equally into core and buffer zones. "Buffer zones include farms and villages, which exist with some restrictions," explains Viswajit, "These are important because sub-adult tigers rely on such zones for easier prey such as cattle, while adult tigers prowl in core zones that have more deer and other prey."

Tiger tourism: then and now

The tiger is a superstar in these parts of town, according to Manav Khanduja of Pugdundee Safaris, which runs the 14-hectare Kings Lodge set in a natural forested estate that contains 10 cottages and 8 stilt houses. "Bandhavgarh is definitely among the top places in the world to spot a tiger," he affirms, "but due to the immense pressure to spot one, tourists are also preferring to frequent buffer zones, which was not the case a few years ago."

Manav recalls a time in Bandhavgarh a couple of decades ago when, during the pre mobile-phone era, "tiger shows" used to be a popular concept. "Elephants were employed to spot tigers, and one elephant would be parked at that place. Tourists who were willing to pay a supplement would climb on the elephant to get a glimpse of the tiger. There was no pressure to sight the tiger back then, because this option was available," he explains. Such 'tiger shows' were ultimately banned by the government. "Today, with the advent of technology and artificial intelligence, we need to find ways to implement responsible tiger tourism," he adds.

Jungle calling

Solar energy powers more than 75 percent of the cottages in the Kings Lodge, a measure taken to promote sustainability. "In a couple of years, we hope to be declared carbon-neutral," says Manav Khanduja of Pugdundee Safaris. The team also runs the popular Pro-Nat programme, a non-profit initiative to groom people who are looking to take up wildlife and associated sectors as a career. While another programme, A-Nat, targets amateur naturalist who are keen but cannot spare too many days, the most recent initiative is 'Y-Nat', primarily focussing on children (in the 12-17 age group) taking up four practical modules revolving around forest-based topics.

A grand sight

We head inside the jungle through Tala Zone, a place that houses more than a dozen caves, some of them filled with bats. Locals believe that the fort here is more than 1000 years old, attached with a story that Lord Rama built it for his brother Lakshman – thus earning the place the name 'Bandhavgarh' (fort for the brother). Subsequently, it became the hunting ground for kings. Maharaja Marthand Singh of Rewa is a man often credited with establishment and conservation of the National Park in the Sixties.

Today, tourists can plan safaris inside the park, but will not be allowed cellphones – in fact, most reserves have lockers or boxes to deposit your mobiles. This is following a Supreme Court ruling in early 2026, aimed at responsible wildlife tourism and less stress for the animals. "In the past, the focus was on observing the beauty and grandeur of the tiger," recalls Viswajit, "Tourists used to spend time focussing on every little detail, including its stripes and injury marks. I hope we can bring back those times following this ban because now, the focus is more on capturing footage and photos. We've had cases of tourists trying to take selfies with the tiger as well. If you avoid the phone, you will enjoy sighting the tigers."

The writer was in Bandhavgarh on invitation from Pugdundee Safaris

Assamese

A psalm of resistance



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In contemporary Indian cinema, few voices capture the anguish and alchemy of rural survival quite like Rima Das. With *Village Rockstars 2*, the auteur returns to the flood-bitten plains of Assam, proving that lightning can indeed strike twice in the same muddy field.

If the 2017 original was a euphoric, barefoot sprint through childhood fantasies, this luminous sequel is a melancholic exhale of coming of age. The cardboard guitars have given way to real strings.

Dhunu, played with natural grace by Bhanita Das, is 17 now and finds herself negotiating a rising Brahmaputra, a flailing mother, a brother losing himself to alcohol, and a piranha called development lurking in still waters. Her instrument has a broken string, and Dhunu knows how to fix it.

It seems the simple act of holding onto a dream requires a quiet revolution. Early in the film, when the teacher demands that the students analyse the floods *before* they can state their life goals, the blackboard prompt echoes life in rural Assam. It tells the audience that survival is a prerequisite to dreaming.

The sequel works more like an impressionistic montage where visual poetry meets an observational documentary-fiction aesthetic. A dragonfly catching attention, Dhunu caressing a real snake, or a confidential teenage conversation creates an immersive, slow-cinema rhythm with multiple layers. Rima uses naturalistic camerawork to freeze small moments.

But gradually the illusion of sunbathed fields, towering green canopies, and a vast, peaceful sky melts away, exposing a crushing reality. As we marvel at the pastoral innocence and friendship captured in gold-hour light, the camera tilts down slightly, and we realise the girls are standing calf-deep in water.

Village Rockstars 2

Director: Rima Das

Cast: Bhanita Das, Basanti Das, Manabendra Das

Synopsis: The sequel follows Dhunu, as her childhood musical dreams collide with the crushing realities of floods, an ailing mother, and a troubled brother.

Rima sprinkles quiet, ordinary moments throughout the film that organically expose rigid social, gender, and economic hierarchies. When the land broker manipulates her brother to sell the misplaced idea of development, it functions as a powerful commentary on how patriarchy and predatory capitalism operate hand-in-hand.

While the village elders police Dhunu's teenage body and her brother buckles under pressure, the mother (Basanti Das) remains a steadfast ally. Through their tender relationship, Rima maps the survival codes of women in a society that puts them on a pedestal but mocks them when they do a man's job. No wonder Dhunu is not enjoying growing up in a world in which *development* is an extractive, violent process that feeds on rural vulnerability and destroys the world that she grew up in.

The film establishes a seamless link between the mother's physical body and the changing Assamese landscape.

Village Rockstars 2 *is currently running in select theatres.*



Karthik Subbaraj's most audacious

In *Dorothy,* Karthik Subbaraj turns a sensitive story of masculine violence into a poignant and radical examination of repression, caste and identity

Tamil

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A man contemplates killing a part of himself because another woman embraced a part of herself that she had been suppressing all her life. This is a thread from the film we are discussing, but also an allegory for how queerphobic individuals on social media have been killing their own humanity these last few days, after the TIFF premiere of Karthik Subbaraj's *Dorothy* revealed that this could be the first major queer entrant in mainstream Tamil cinema.

In a way, *Dorothy*, starring Sananth, Rishikanth and Keerthy Suresh, has exposed queerphobia in modern Tamil society even before its release.

The film's conceit is to make you believe it is a story about two men, Karthi and Subbu, who fight over a woman, the titular Dorothy. The promo materials seem designed with this in mind, but the brilliance of Karthik's screenplay is that, at the end of the day, even when you know there's a queer theme, the film still tells that story in a breathtaking way.

We have Subbu (Sananth), a young man who looks up to Bruce Lee and spends much of his time with his best friend, Karthi (Rishikanth). Raised as a 'kadaikutty' by ruffians in a womanless household, Subbu yearns for motherly love, which he first sees in Karthi's mother and later, in his sister-in-law, Dorothy (Keerthy Suresh).

Karthi, on the other hand, starts as a young, scared boy who did not have a father to protect him and his mother from a cruel, patriarchal world. However, as life has it, Karthi grows up as someone who seems more suited to Subbu's world, and vice versa.

The first half of the film shows how Subbu and Karthi find each other, how they complete each other, and how they, in a way, become each other. At the beginning, Subbu tells Karthi, "Aambala azha koodadhu da (Men shouldn't cry)" – and this thought ends up causing the first layer of rust in Karthi. Even after the former learns the truth of the matter – as Karthi's mother says, there's no gender to emotions – a tender part of Karthi begins to corrode. At a time when incel culture is suffocating Indian social media, it's a crucial work of writing that underlines how a heartbreak caused by patriarchy fuels this toxicity in Karthi.

In fact, every crucial moment in this story is inadvertently caused by women – through her wedding, her affection, her death, or simply her existence. Whenever a character finds a woman's shoulder to lean on or confide in, destruction snatches the moment away.

But there's a well somewhere in our world where femininity is stored and repressed. Eventually, it flows as a river. And when femininity decides to break out, it can obliterate anything in its path, and this fierce nature of femininity in the face of oppression is what *Dorothy* celebrates.

In a film that could be seen as a follow-up to his 2016 film *Iraivi*, Karthik Subbaraj looks far more mature. He lets his characters be themselves and show who they are. Through a steady buildup of character, Karthik's script lets you experience being a feminine presence in a hypermasculine, cis-heteronormative world. He shows that women too can fight like Bruce Lee, but there is also bravery and intellect in walking away from a fight.

Karthik's most cohesively written script, *Dorothy* is also his most progressive take on how caste, class and gender intersect. From a dialogue a child utters when asked his caste to how the cops go easy on their caste members, casteism exists comfortably with patriarchy in this world; in fact, caste also explains why Subbu gets to be closer to Dorothy and not Karthi.

The filmmaker conveys both large and small ideas efficiently; even the way a character eats parotta becomes a sentiment, with a shot likening the salna flowing over parotta to blood draining out. Or take, for instance, how a reference to the famous comic 'Irumbu Kai Maayavi' accrues new meaning when Karthi injures his hand. Speaking of the comic, Karthik Subbaraj has never missed an opportunity to celebrate cinephilia – from a perfectly placed cinema bandi-style advert of *Nayakan* to a shot of a man looking at Grace Jones' thighs in the poster of *A View to Kill*.

The Rajinikanth fan in Karthik also doesn't miss paying tribute to the superstar of the 80s through Rishikanth, who resembles Rajini; there's a reason why Rishi's hairstyle looks like Rajini's in *Thalapathy* and why he opts for a different look in some portions. Interestingly, the Tarantino fan in Karthik makes up for some of the damage *Once Upon a Time... in Hollywood* inflicted upon Bruce Lee fans.

And no call to nostalgia seems complete without maestro Ilaiyaraaja, whose music becomes a character itself in Dorothy. Fans of the composer have been eagerly waiting for the film ever since Karthik announced that he is using 'Do Anything' from the composer's album *How to Name It?*, but nothing prepares you for the weight of the moment the track is used in. In his 1551st movie, Ilaiyaraaja once again displays an understanding of when to vanish into the background and let the material speak for itself, and when the song must come to add new meaning or emotional heft to the text.

For many years, Tamil queer audiences who took a liking to World Cinema titles such as *All About My Mother* and *A Fantastic Woman* have yearned for a queer film that reflects their lives with accurate representation. *Dorothy* might be the start of a queer revolution in mainstream Tamil cinema, and Karthik has shown real effort to understand some of what queer life in India means. The film allows you to understand the importance of pronouns, while a scene featuring a scorpion illustrates that even Nature is fluid.

To speak in the language of hate that *Dorothy* seems to be attracting online, if this queerphobia and immorality are a zombie herd of ignorance and apathy, more mainstream representation of queer themes will be the flash flood of sense and scientific temper. All it took was one audacious filmmaker, a daring producer, and a passionate cast to pull off what might just become the most important Indian film of the year. And so, the wells will fill, the rivers will swell, and nobody can stop them.

Dorothy

Director: Karthik Subbaraj

Cast: Sananth, Rishikanth, Keerthy Suresh, Muthukumar

Storyline: Two men bound by friendship and violence find their lives transformed when a woman enters their world and awakens parts of themselves they have long suppressed

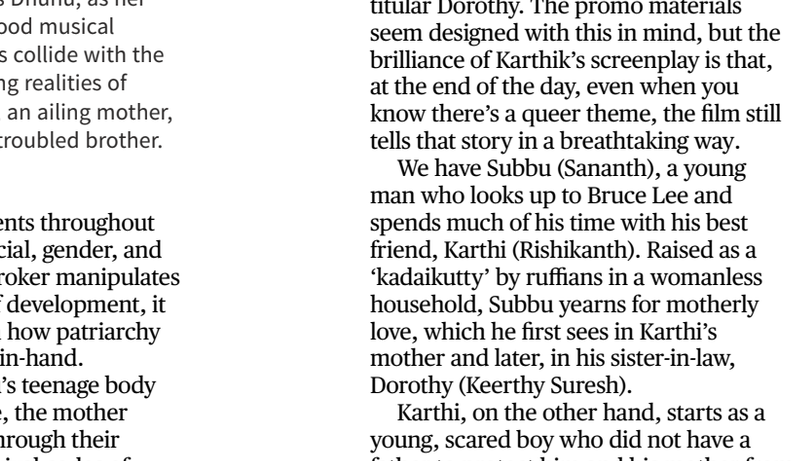
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Dorothy *is currently running in theatres*

An emotionally distant, epic misfire

Telugu

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The Paradise begins by paying tribute to some of the Indian cinema legends we have lost in recent times. It also remembers revolutionary Telangana poet Gummadi Vittal Rao, better known as Gaddar. It is director Srikanth Odela's way of tipping his hat to his Telangana roots and the region's textured history.

In his debut, *Dasara*, also starring Nani, Srikanth explored caste hierarchies around Telangana's coal mines during the era of prohibition, weaving a tale of friendship, loss and revenge.

With his second collaboration with Nani, *The Paradise*, the stakes are higher. Within the familiar template of an underdog hero rising against powerful oppressors, Srikanth raises questions of identity, voting rights and the existential crisis of a fictional marginalised community.

The effort that has gone into building a fictional world set in Secunderabad's Paradise locality in the 1980s is evident on screen, with a grunge-meets-dystopian visual aesthetic, cinematography by Ch. Sai, and symbolism contrasting lowly crows with preying eagles. There is plenty of rage, violence and desperate cries for help from voices hoping to be heard. What the film lacks, though, is the emotional heft to translate its ambitious ideas into an absorbing narrative.

Srikanth expects the audience, swiftly transported into this dystopian setting, not to question how the plight of a tribe called Savaari, supposedly settled in the heart of Secunderabad, could go unnoticed by the administration. This is not a remote village off the radar. Yet the film never convincingly establishes the tribe's history or plight enough to make us invest in their journey.

In an early scene in *The Paradise*, a heavily pregnant young woman leads the Savaari tribe to an administrative office, raising slogans about their identity. We see the visuals, hear the cries and yet do not identify with them. The introduction of antagonist Shikanja Maalik (veteran actor Mohan Babu), and the inhuman treatment meted out to the pregnant woman, are brutal, yet something feels amiss. Is it the repetitive use of emotionally manipulative scenes in action dramas, or a failure of storytelling? The question lingered through the film.

The childhood portions of the protagonist, Jadal (Nani), named for his plaits, fare better. The moody black-and-brown visuals of the Savaari tribe, contrasted with the opulence of Shikanja Maalik and his son Vikram (Raghav Juyal), also feel stereotypical, given the number of action dramas set in similarly eccentric worlds.

Several characters who might have seemed radical or interesting on paper, played by Kayadu Lohar, Sampoornesh Babu, Easwari Rao, Mohan Babu and Raghav Juyal, fail to make the desired impact.

The only characters that merit attention are those played by Nani and Sonali Kulkarni. Sonali's arc is largely predictable, but she is sincere in her portrayal. Nani shakes off his man-next-door image with the physical transformation required for the role, but in the absence of a well-written script, he appears rather lost. For one of the most versatile actors in present-day Telugu cinema, *The Paradise* feels like a misstep.

The pre-intermission sequence, the 'Aaya Sher' song and a conversation between Sonali and Nani are among the few moments when *The Paradise* holds interest. The rest is a test of endurance.

Certain portions also feel hurriedly put together, with rapid editing shifts and underwhelming sound mixing that makes some dialogue barely audible.

The Paradise is also liberal with its violence. Close-up shots of violence inflicted in increasingly graphic ways, including an electric shock administered to a heavily pregnant woman are shown. Several shots made me turn away from the screen, but they did not make me feel for the characters. The problem lies in the narrative's failure to establish its world and characters effectively.

Had *The Paradise* been written better, it could have been a conflict between a protagonist who wants his tribe to lead a respectable life and a man thirsting for political power and eager to step out of his father's shadow. What exists now is a massive misfire.

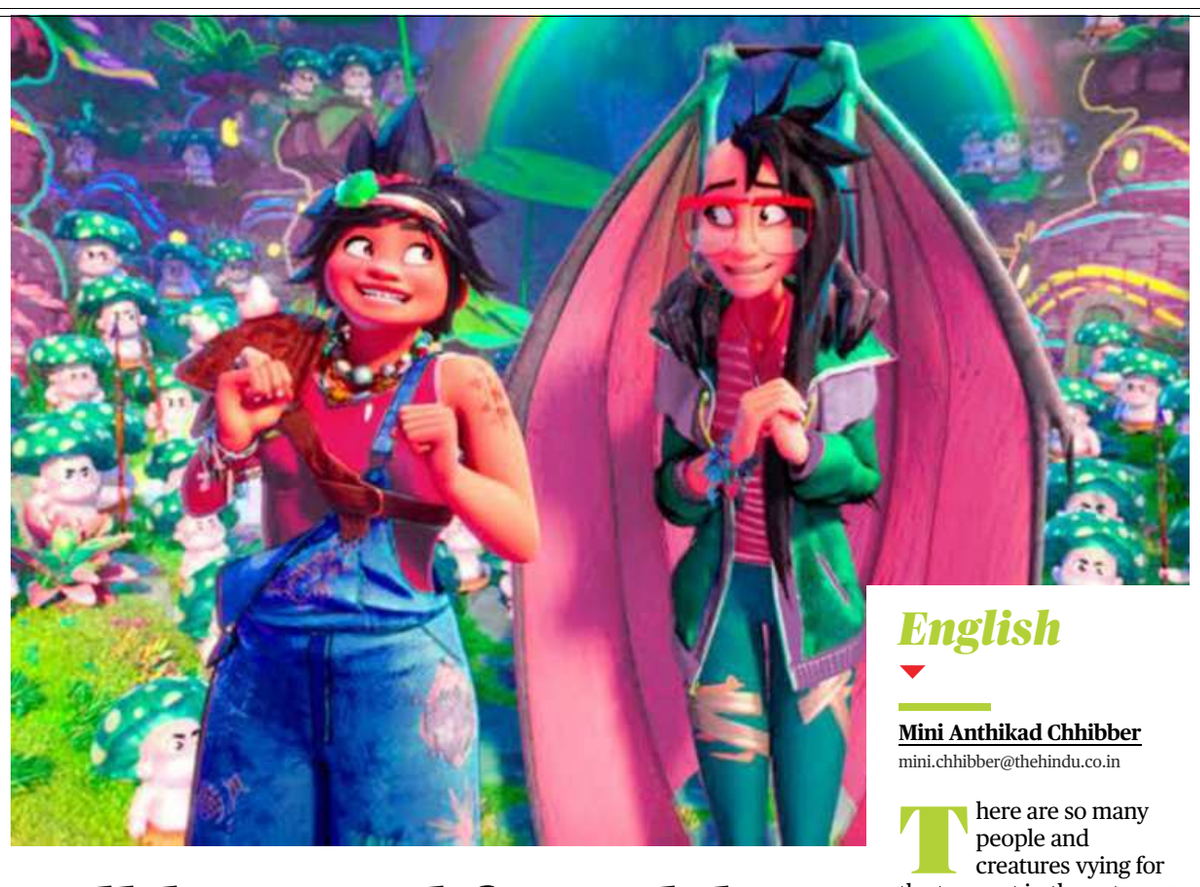
The Paradise

Director: Srikanth Odela

Cast: Nani, Kayadu Lohar, Sonali Kulkarni, Mohanbabu, Raghav Juyal

Storyline: The fight for survival and identity of a tribe forces a man to lead a rebellion filled with bloodshed.

The Paradise *is currently running in theatres*



Forgotten Island

Directors: Joel Crawford, Januel Mercado

Cast: H E R, Liza Soberano, Dave Franco, Jenny Slate, Manny Jacinto, Dolly de Leon, Jo Koy, Ronny Chieng, Kevin McCann, Lea Salonga

Storyline: Jo and Raissa's lifetime of friendship comes under strain when Raissa accepts an offer to study at Caltech

Folklore and friendship

English

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There are so many people and creatures vying for the top spot in the cuteness sweepstakes in *Forgotten Island*, the latest animation feature written and directed by Joel Crawford and Januel Mercado. There is the sweetest little three-eyed baby demon, Bungi (Manny Jacinto), who is terrified of getting pink eye.

There is also the confused Raww (Dave Franco) a were-wolf/dog. Batiba (Jenny Slate) the memory demon is quite cuddly too as is Truffle Wuffle (Ronny Chieng) the king of the Duwende people, who is full of dignity and beyond adorable as well. Even the evil, terrifying Manang (Lea Salonga) has a tender backstory. And Prince Mermahn (Kevin McCann), while being just that little bit silly is rather handsome too.

The two friends at the centre of the story, the rambunctious Jo (H.E.R.) and the genius Raissa (Liza Soberano) are charming. The movie opens in 1990s Philippines where a young Jo describes the fabulous island of Nakali where all manner of beasts roam.

She is sent to the principal's office for attacking a classmate who made fun of her stories. Jo meets Raissa, who defended her, at the principal's office and the two girls become friends over charm bracelets, mixed tapes, and Arnold Schwarzenegger films at Jo's beloved grandmother, Lola's (Dolly de Leon) house.

Years go by and after Lola's passing, Jo is at a loose end going from one pointless job to another while Raissa gets admission to Caltech. Though Raissa's mother is disapproving of the girls' friendship, feeling Jo will only drag Raissa down, the night before Raissa is to fly out, the girls finally find the portal to Nakali and have a mind-blowing adventure.

Forgotten Island with its retro animation inspired by Filipino folk art and the graphic style of the '90s with eye-popping colours, makes you feel as though you are on a sugar rush after a triple shot of espresso. The emphasis on memory and remembering is heart-warming as are the Polaroid pictures and other physical tokens of memories.

Batiba, who is scared of stepping outside, and lives her life vicariously through the "all you-can-eat buffet of memories" is a poignant creation. And then there is the warmth of friendship between two disparate people who need each other to become whole.

While the film might sometimes feel overstuffed, it does not do so to the point of becoming wearisome. The voice cast is warm and inviting and the bright pops of colour grab the eye and keep it. All the weird and wonderful creatures from Filipino folklore lend an endearing freshness to the film, while Jo and Raissa's friendship and shared adventures give the story a solid emotional core.

Forgotten Island *is currently running in theatres*

Snippets



D 56: Dhanush and Vadivelu to share screen space; film goes on floors

The filming of Dhanush's upcoming movie, tentatively titled *D 56,* has begun. The Tamil movie is directed by Tamizharasan Pachamuthu.

D 56 is the first collaboration between Dhanush and Pachamuthu. The movie is jointly produced by Naga Vamsi of Sithara Entertainments, Haritha Lingasamy of Primark Productions and Sai Soujanya of Srikar Studios.

The shooting commenced with a special pooja at the Karuppasamy Temple near Madurai. The event was attended by the film's cast and crew along with several prominent personalities. Veteran actor Vadivelu is set to play a prominent roel in the movie. Preity Mukhundhan is the female lead in the movie.



Ranbir Kapoor's look from Sanjay Leela Bhansali's *Love & War* unveiled

The first look of Ranbir Kapoor from Sanjay Leela Bhansali's upcoming period-drama, *Love & War* was unveiled by the makers on September 24. Also starring Alia Bhatt and Vicky Kaushal, *Love & War* will be released in theatres on January 21, 2027.

In the first look poster, Ranbir dons a moustache look wearing shades and driving a blue car with his bloodied hand handing through its door.

The film has been billed as a period-romance which is set against the backdrop of war. It marks Vicky's first collaboration with Bhansali while Ranbir is set to reunite with the filmmaker after 19 years since *Saawariya* (2007).



SK 27: Sivakarthikeyan, Kayadu Lohar starrer launched

Tamil star Sivakarthikeyan's next, tentatively titled *SK 27,* will be produced by the noted production house Sathya Jyothi Films. The makers announced the project with a poster.

T G Thyagarajan presents the film, produced by Sendhil Thyagarajan and Arjun Thyagarajan. Saravanan and Sai Siddharth are the co-producers. Sivakarthikeyan will play the lead role, with Kayadu Lohar as the female lead. This marks the first collaboration between the two actors.

The movie will be directed by Ramkumar Balakrishnan, who previously gained widespread attention with his National Award winning film *Parking*.



Vivisection of televised virtue

Lance Oppenheim turns the machine back onto its makers, in *Primetime*. This is exploitation art made from exploitative artists, and it's wickedly entertaining to witness

English

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Primetime

Director: Lance Oppenheim

Cast: Robert Pattinson, Merritt Wever, Skyler Gisondo, Matthew Maher, Phoebe Bridgers

Storyline: Chris Hansen, host of "To Catch a Predator," sets out to make television history in 2006.

Lance Oppenheim's feature debut takes the 2007 Esquire investigation "Tonight on Dateline This Man Will Die" and turns the rise and collapse of *To Catch a Predator* into a psychological crime thriller, with Robert Pattinson playing series host Chris Hansen as he sets out to make television history. Watching Hansen turn the exploitation of evil into a narcissistic feedback loop is a perverse sort of entertainment. But trying to meaningfully dissect the opportunism and self-interest baked into his righteous mission to "cleanse the world of an ancient evil," however, has already earned the ire of a corner of the internet that could use some remedial media literacy.

Hansen became the face of *To Catch a Predator* after *Dateline NBC* began working with Perverted Justice, the online vigilante outfit whose members posed as minors in chat rooms and arranged meetings with men they had lured into the sting. Hansen would then appear at the house, introduce himself as an NBC correspondent and read the men their own messages back to them, turning the sick internet exchange into a piece of television theatre before the police intervened. The timing was perfect. America was already living through the post-9/11 expansion of surveillance and moral crusading, with the internet had developing the lawless reputation of a place where anybody sinister could be hiding behind a screen name. *To Catch a Predator* brought that specific anxiety into every living room in the United States. By 2006 it was the highest-rated programme of the night, so the prospect of moving Hansen into a regular primetime slot was hardly a modest ambition.

Oppenheim is an excellent fit for this material. The filmmaker has talked about how he grew up watching *To Catch a Predator*, while his previous documentaries *Some Kind of Heaven* and *Ren Faire* have both followed people ensconced in the peculiar realities they have built around themselves.

Robert Pattinson is extraordinary. I genuinely think this is the best performance of his career. He has found something incredibly foul in Hansen. Every one of his gestures and mannerisms feels like vetted by corporate communications and calibrated for an audience, even when there is nobody around to impress. Watching him rehearse those filthy chat-log exchanges is especially unnerving because it feels like Pattinson subjected himself to the same humiliating little rituals required to get Hansen into his body. Pattinson's twitchiness and penchant for eccentricties makes the whole thing worse because he buries it inside the beige blandness of this middle-aged network correspondent. He seems to instinctively grasp the ridiculousness of Hansen's private mythology, which makes every one of his self-serious flourishes even funnier and every ounce of vanity a little more repellent.

The supporting cast is just as sharp. Skyler Gisondo is terrific as Dan, the young decoy whose participation makes the production of *To Catch a Predator* look considerably more profane from the inside. Hansen takes an almost paternal interest in him, coaching him through the stings while gradually pulling him further into the moral swamp of the job. Gisondo starts with Dan's awkwardness played almost lightly, then lets it curdle into something genuinely disturbing as the sheer trauma of the work begins to take its toll. Merritt Wever is magnificent as Andie Bender, the producer trying to keep the operation running. She brings a tired authority to the enterprise but there is also something so conniving about her power trip in her performance. Matthew Maher is positively disgusting as Xavier, the online vigilante behind *Perverted Justice*. Phoebe Bridgers is also surprisingly good as Del in her feature debut. There is not a single performance here that feels out of place.

To Catch a Predator looked bizarre when it aired. Oppenheim understands that the ugliness of the original footage had a distinctness of its own and pushes its latent unreality towards an *I Saw the TV Glow*-adjacent uncanniness. He crafts the look of the film around that ugliness so completely – through the early 2000's camcorder grain, the garish lighting, the lens smears and washed-out colours – that the cheapness feels rather seductive. The boxy, pixelated 4:3 frame also makes every room feel claustrophobically small for the people inside it. And the image often looks as though it has been copied, compressed and copied again, which kind of suits a film about television people manufacturing reality for other television people. But the colour grading is especially gorgeous and deserves massive credit. And the sound design is just as good, with television hiss, electronic interference and stray bursts of noise creeping into every shot.

Over its NBC run, *To Catch a Predator* produced 238 apprehensions, yet only 36 ended in guilty pleas or convictions. Its entanglement with online vigilantes, police and television raised questions about entrapment, evidentiary standards and the jurisdiction of journalism itself. But Hansen seems to exist in a universe where those distinctions have already been settled. That conviction gives him an almost disconcerting freedom from self-scrutiny, and it's almost comical until you realise how completely it immunises him from examining his own conduct.

Oppenheim is doing something genuinely devious with *Primetime*. He takes the moral alibi that made *To Catch a Predator* so consumable and subjects the act of watching to the same scrutiny. The programme's entire premise depends on converting another person's humiliation into a public service, with spectatorship laundering the appetite for punishment into something socially respectable. The obscenity of reality television is that it can absorb voyeurism, humiliation and punitive pleasures, and repackage them under the garb of public interest.

The delicious irony is imagining Hansen sitting through *Primetime* as his own moral crusade is transmuted into prestige entertainment for the very audience that has spent years consecrating him as a kind of secular patron saint of potential victims. Surely that cannot constitute an abuse of spectatorship. Surely this is an acceptable commodification of evil. Surely this is *still* God's work.

Primetime *is currently running in theatres*